

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-12-28

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 beloved friends,
2 in the course of the four year plan, we have been reviewing those laws of
3 the kitáb-i-Aqdas which are not yet universally applied, in order to deter-
4 mine which of them it would be timely to implement now.
5 in every land we see a growing thirst for spiritual life and moral clarity.
6 There is recognition of the ineffectiveness of plans and programs for human
7 betterment which are not rooted in lives of spiritual awareness and ethical virtue.
who should be better equipped to satisfy this longing than those
8 who are already inspired by the Teachings of bahá'u'lláh and aided by his
9 power?
10 we have determined, therefore, that it is imperative for all the believers to
11 deepen their awareness of the blessings conferred by the laws which directly
12 foster the devotional life of the individual and, thus, of the community. 314.1
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316 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
317 698The essentials of these laws are known to all bahá'ís, but acquiring greater
318 insight into their significance must include carrying out all the divinely
319 revealed aspects of their observance. These are the laws which pertain to
320 obligatory prayer, fasting and recitation of the greatest Name ninety-five
321 times a day.

bahá'u'lláh asserts: "o ne who performeth neither good deeds nor acts

322 of worship is like unto a tree which beareth no fruit, and an action which leaveth no
trace. whosoever experienceth the holy ecstasy of worship will

323 refuse to barter such an act or any praise of god for all that existeth in the
324 world. fasting and obligatory prayer are as two wings to man's life. blessed
325 be the one who soareth with their aid in the heaven of the love of god, the
lord of all worlds."

The friends have long been familiar with the great importance which

326 bahá'u'lláh attaches to daily obligatory prayer and to the observance of the
327 fast, but a number of aspects of the law, such as those concerning ablutions, traveling
and the compensation for prayers missed, remained to be made universally applicable. This
step is now taken. Thus all elements of the laws
328 dealing with obligatory prayer and fasting are, without any exception, now
329 applicable.
330 we have also decided that it is timely for bahá'ís in every land to take
331 to their hearts the words of the kitáb-i-Aqdas: "i t hath been ordained that
332 every believer in god, the lord of judgment, shall, each day, having washed
333 his hands and then his face, seat himself and, turning unto god, repeat
334 'Alláh-u-Abhá' ninety-five times. Such was the decree of the maker of the
**heavens when, with majesty and power, he established himself upon
the thrones of his Names."**

335 315-1 let all experience the spiritual enrichment
336 brought to their souls by this simple act of worshipful meditation.

The spiritual growth generated by individual devotions is reinforced

337 by loving association among the friends in every locality, by worship as a community
and by service to the faith and to one's fellow human be-
338 ings. These communal aspects of the godly life relate to the law of the
339 mashriqu'l-A dhkár which appears in the kitáb-i-Aqdas. Although the time
340 has not come for the building of local mashriqu'l-A dhkárs, the holding of
341 regular meetings for worship open to all and the involvement of bahá'í com-
342 munities in projects of humanitarian service are expressions of this element of bahá'í
life and a further step in the implementation of the law of g od.

343 315-1. kA, ¶18.315.4

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316 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

317 699bahá'u'lláh has written: “ we have adorned the heaven of utterance with
318 the stars of divine wisdom and holy ordinances as a bounty on our part.
319 verily, we are the ever-forgiving, the most generous. o friends of god
320 throughout the regions! know ye the value of these days and cling unto

**whatsoever hath been sent down from god, the most great, the most
exalted. verily, he remembereth you in the most great prison, and in-**

321 structeth you in that which will cause you to draw nigh unto a station that
322 delighteth the eyes of the pure in heart. glory rest upon you and upon those
323 who have attained unto that living fountain which floweth forth from my

wondrous pen.”

324 it is our prayer at the Sacred Threshold that the greater attention to the
325 spiritual heart of the Teachings which these laws express will enhance the devotion of
the friends to the Source of all bounties and attract to the cause
326 the receptive souls among his spiritually famished children.

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Passing of Amatu'l-Bahá Rúhíyyih Khánúm

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]